Public Relations Review 38 (2012) 83–88

Contents lists available at SciVerse ScienceDirect

Public Relations Review

Crisis response and crisis timing strategies, two sides of the same coin

An-Sofie Claeys[a,b,*], Verolien Cauberghe[a,1]

[a] Ghent University, Faculty of Social and Political Sciences, Department of Communication Sciences, Korte Meer 7-11, 9000 Ghent, Belgium
[b] Royal Military Academy, Faculty of Political and Military Sciences, Department of Economics, Management and Leadership, Av. De la Renaissance 30, B-1000 Brussels, Belgium

ARTICLE INFO

Article history:
Received 5 April 2011
Received in revised form 7 September 2011
Accepted 12 September 2011

Keywords:
Public relations
Crisis response strategies
Crisis timing strategies
Reputation
Credibility

ABSTRACT

This study investigates the moderating impact of the timing of crisis disclosure on the effect of crisis response strategies on organizational post-crisis reputation. It proposes that self-disclosing a crisis allows organizations to avoid explicitly taking or rejecting responsibility by means of a crisis response strategy. A 2 (crisis timing strategy: ex-ante vs. ex-post) × 2 (crisis response strategy: response strategy vs. objective information only) between-subjects factorial design was conducted among 137 participants. The results show that organizations that do not steal thunder better use a reputation restoring crisis response strategy than just providing stakeholders objective information about what happened. In addition, the results demonstrate that if an organization steals thunder, it is not necessary to offer reputation restoring crisis response strategies such as an apology. These findings stress the importance of timing to disclose crisis information in addition to the content of crisis communication strategies.

© 2011 Elsevier Inc. All rights reserved.

1. Introduction

Organizations in crisis face severe reputational threats. The more responsible an organization is for a crisis, the larger the reputational damage will be (Coombs, 2007). This damage can be minimized by the correct public relations strategy, namely saying the right words at the right moment (Coombs, 2004). According to the Situational Crisis Communication Theory (SCCT), when the reputational threat as the result of a crisis is mild, it is sufficient that an organization offers objective information to minimize the reputational damage. If the reputational threat is severe, it is strongly advised that the organization integrates reputation restoring crisis response strategies (e.g., apology, denial) into its communication strategy. The choice between these crisis response strategies is often difficult (Coombs, 2007). Public relations practitioners might find it hard to convince their management and the legal department of the organization of the importance of taking responsibility for a crisis. By offering an explicit apology, organizations open themselves to lawsuits and consequently to financial losses (Coombs & Holladay, 2008). Coombs and Holladay (2008) have found however, that compensation and sympathy are as effective as an apology in shaping stakeholders perceptions of the organization taking responsibility for the crisis, because these crisis response strategies focus on the victims' needs. Self-disclosing a crisis (a crisis timing strategy), as an alternative to crisis response strategies however, can be equally effective in minimizing crisis damage (Arpan & Roskos-Ewoldsen, 2005). Similarly to crisis response strategies, crisis timing strategies are used strategically to reduce crisis damage (Dolnik, Case, & Williams, 2003) and differ in the amount of responsibility an organization in crisis is perceived to take (Arpan & Roskos-Ewoldsen, 2005).

* Corresponding author. Tel.: +32 494 26 69 32/2 742 63 89; fax: +32 9 264 69 92.
E-mail addresses: ansofie.claeys@ugent.be, an.sofie.claeys@rma.ac.be (A.-S. Claeys), verolien.cauberghe@ugent.be (V. Cauberghe).
[1] Tel.: +32 472 230787; fax: +32 9 264 69 92.

0363-8111/$ – see front matter © 2011 Elsevier Inc. All rights reserved.
doi:10.1016/j.pubrev.2011.09.001

2. Crisis communication strategies

Corporations use crisis communication strategies to protect their reputation (Coombs & Holladay, 2002). In general there are two types of crisis communication strategies: (1) the crisis response strategies (e.g., denial, apology) (Coombs, 2007) and (2) the crisis timing strategies (e.g., stealing thunder) (Arpan & Roskos-Ewoldsen, 2005).

2.1. Crisis response strategies

According to the Situational Crisis Communication Theory (SCCT), organizations should select a crisis response strategy that is determined by the amount of crisis responsibility attributed to the organization (Coombs, 2007; Coombs & Holladay, 2002). Research has confirmed that in case of a preventable crisis (a crisis that could be prevented by the organization which therefore holds a high degree of responsibility for the crisis), crisis managers should use accommodating rebuild strategies (e.g., apology). In case of a victim crisis (a crisis for which the organization holds a low degree of responsibility), managers can use defensive denial strategies (e.g., denial, scapegoat) (Coombs & Holladay, 1996; Huang, 2006). However, according to the SCCT, in case of a crisis that inflicts a mild reputational threat, it is enough to provide stakeholders with only objective information about the crisis without adding an additional crisis response strategy (Coombs, 2004). If there is a severe reputational threat however, it is necessary to integrate a suitable reputation restoring crisis response strategy in addition to the objective information of the crisis. The more responsible the organization is, however, and the more severe the reputational threat, the more responsibility an organization should take in its crisis response (Coombs, 2007). Yet, the use of highly accommodative strategies is often discouraged by legal advisors; because of the financial liabilities they might incur (Coombs & Holladay, 2002). It is therefore interesting to find an alternative that allows organizations in a preventable crisis to minimize the reputational damage by offering objective information only.

2.2. Crisis timing strategies

Stealing thunder is a proactive crisis timing strategy defined as follows: “When an organization steals thunder, it breaks the news about its own crisis before the crisis is discovered by the media or other interested parties” (Arpan & Roskos-Ewoldsen, 2005, p. 425). The goal of an ex-ante crisis timing strategy (cf. stealing thunder) is to reduce crisis damage (Dolnik et al., 2003), because if an organization does not disclose incriminating information, its opponents will, with twice as much impact (Mauet, 2007). Studies focusing on the importance of crisis timing strategies were initiated in the context of research on lawsuits (Arpan & Pompper, 2003). Participants in the ex-ante crisis timing condition (i.e., stealing thunder) were less likely to find a defendant guilty than those in the ex-post crisis timing condition (i.e., thunder) (Williams, Bourgeois, & Croyle, 1993). In line with these results, crisis communication research found that organizations that use an ex-ante crisis timing strategy are perceived as more credible than those who use an ex-post crisis timing strategy (Arpan & Pompper, 2003; Arpan & Roskos-Ewoldsen, 2005).

Several explanations for the positive effects of an ex-ante crisis timing strategy have been proposed and studied. According to the inoculation theory, stealing thunder offers organizations the opportunity to warn stakeholders about an upcoming attack, and inoculate them with a weaker version of the attack (Williams et al., 1993). The change of meaning hypothesis on the other hand proposes that when organizations reveal negative information, stakeholders will attempt to reconcile the apparent paradox by changing the meaning of the disclosure, in order to make it consistent with their existing beliefs about the organization (Arpan & Pompper, 2003). Other possible explanations that have received attention are the framing hypothesis, according to which an ex-ante crisis timing strategy works because it allows organizations to frame the crisis in their own terms and downplay its severity (Williams et al., 1993), and the commodity theory, according to which an external attack loses its value after an organization has self-disclosed the same information first (Arpan & Pompper, 2003). The potential moderating effects of these crisis timing strategies, however, have not received much research attention in the past.

3. Hypotheses development

Both the content and the timing of crisis communication allow organizations to actively manage their reputations in crises. Crisis timing strategies have received far less attention than crisis response strategies, but are of equal importance to minimize crisis damage (Arpan & Roskos-Ewoldsen, 2005). Similar to the crisis response strategies, crisis timing strategies allow organizations to either reject or take responsibility. An ex-post crisis response strategy implies that the organization does not take full responsibility. An ex-ante crisis timing strategy on the other hand suggests that an organization takes responsibility for the crisis, which is recommended in case of preventable crises (Archer & Burleson, 1980).

Research on crisis response strategies tested the different types of crisis response strategies in an ex-post crisis timing strategy condition (Coombs, 2004; Huang, 2006). In these ex-post crisis timing strategy situations, the use of crisis response strategies significantly reduces the crisis damage compared to giving only objective information about the crisis (Coombs, 2004; Coombs & Holladay, 2008). However, the impact of the different types of crisis responses has not yet been tested in an ex-ante crisis timing strategy condition. If an organization steals thunder or uses a rebuild crisis response strategy to repair the reputational damage, the organization takes full responsibility for the crisis. Since the Situational Crisis Communication

Theory proposes that for preventable crises the organization should take a large amount of responsibility for the crisis (Coombs, 2007) both rebuild crisis response strategies and ex-ante crisis timing strategies will match this type of crisis in terms of responsibility taken by the organization. Since crisis timing strategies are equally effective as crisis response strategies (Arpan & Roskos-Ewoldsen, 2005), it can be expected that in the ex-ante crisis timing strategy condition, offering only objective information will have the same impact on crisis damage as using a rebuild crisis response strategy. Hence we expect that:

H1a. In case of an ex-ante crisis timing strategy, providing objective crisis information versus using a crisis response strategy has no significant different impact on the organizational credibility.

H1b. In case of an ex-post crisis timing strategy, providing objective crisis information will have a more significantly negative impact on organizational credibility compared to using a crisis response strategy.

An ex-ante crisis timing strategy can lower perceptions of crisis severity (Arpan & Roskos-Ewoldsen, 2005) and of guilt or responsibility (Williams et al., 1993) through an increase in perceived organizational credibility. Organizational credibility is closely related to perceptions of reputation (Coombs & Holladay, 2002). It is therefore expected that the positive effect of an ex-ante crisis timing strategy on organizational reputation is mediated by organizational credibility.

H2. Organizational credibility mediates the interaction effect between crisis response and crisis timing on post-crisis reputation.

4. Method

4.1. Design and stimuli

A two (crisis timing strategy: ex-ante vs. ex-post) × two (crisis response strategy: response strategy vs. objective crisis information only) between-subjects factorial experimental design was used to investigate the hypotheses. Four different scenarios of a fictitious organization, active in computer hardware, were used to manipulate the content and timing of organizational crisis communication. The crisis involved a fictitious fraud case (a preventable crisis) (Coombs & Holladay, 2002). In the ex-ante crisis timing condition, the organization itself reveals the information about the fraud, whereas in the ex-post crisis timing condition, the public prosecutor brings out the crisis information and the organization simply reacts to these allegations. In all scenarios, the organization offers objective information on the crisis. In the crisis response strategy condition the organization adds an apology, a rebuild crisis response strategy, which matches with the preventable crisis (Coombs, 2007).

4.2. Participants and procedure

Data were collected online from 137 respondents through a convenience sample taken from a random group of Dutch-speaking Belgian individuals. The respondents were contacted through email and were invited to participate in the study by following a link to the online questionnaire which was drafted in Dutch. They were randomly exposed to one of the four experimental conditions. They read the scenario that described the crisis, the timing of disclosure and the content of the organizational response. The average age of the participants was 34 years ($SD = 15.01$; range = 19–86 years). Approximately 44% were male, 56% were female.

4.3. Measures

Organizational reputation was measured with the Reputation Quotient scale of Fombrun, Gardberg, and Sever (2000) ($\alpha = .89$) (e.g., "*I have a good feeling about this company*"). The twenty items were rated on a 7-point Likert scale.

Organizational credibility was measured through a 7-point semantic differential scale based on Beltramini's (1982) believability scale ($\alpha = .91$) (e.g., *honest* vs. *dishonest*).

Organizational responsibility for a crisis was measured using a 7-point four-item Likert scale of Griffin, Babin, and Darden (1992) (e.g., "*How responsible was the organization with respect to the crisis?*") ($\alpha = .74$) to allow to establish that the fraud was considered as a preventable crisis. According to the SCCT, preventable crises inflict high attributions of responsibility (Coombs & Holladay, 2002); as a consequence they will inflict severe crisis damage.

4.4. Pre-test and manipulation check

A pre-test using a within-subjects design was performed with 20 respondents in order to check the manipulations of the crisis response and the timing strategy. A multiple-choice questionnaire was used. First, respondents had to evaluate the content of the crisis communication and indicate if the organization used a crisis response strategy or offered objective crisis information only. All respondents in the pre-test matched the content of the crisis response to the scenarios correctly. Similar results were obtained for the manipulation of crisis timing strategies, which were matched correctly to each scenario by

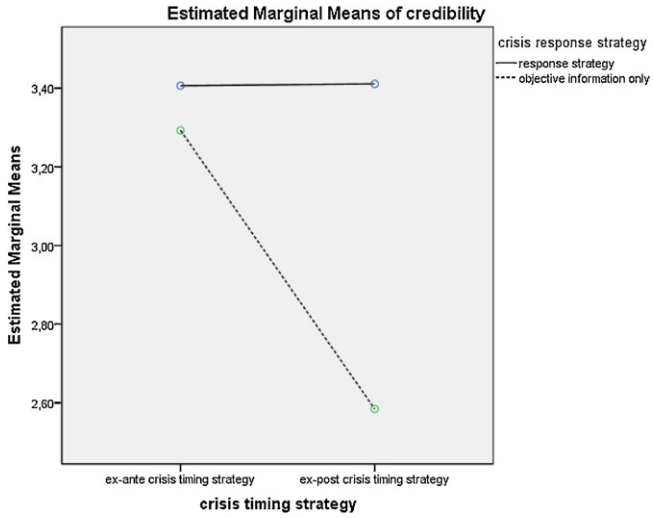

Fig. 1. Interaction between crisis timing strategy and crisis response strategy on credibility.

all respondents. Responsibility was perceived sufficiently high ($M = 6.15$, $SD = .95$) for a preventable crisis type (on a 7-point Likert scale).

The crisis type proved to be manipulated correctly in the manipulation check as well ($M = 5.62$, $SD = 1.09$). Concerning crisis timing, of respondents in the ex-ante crisis timing condition, 77% judged that the organization had self-disclosed the crisis. About 96% of respondents in the ex-post crisis timing condition felt like the Public Prosecutor disclosed the crisis. For the manipulation check of organizational response, 85% of all respondents in the information-only condition claimed that the organization only offered information. In the crisis response strategy condition, 94% of the respondents claimed that the organization offered an apology.

5. Results

To address the interaction effect of the crisis response strategy and crisis timing strategy on organizational credibility, a univariate two-way ANOVA was conducted. There appears to be a significant interaction effect on organizational credibility ($F(1, 133) = 3.70$, $p = .056$) (cf. Fig. 1). When an organization in crisis uses an ex-ante crisis timing strategy, it does not matter if it uses a crisis response strategy ($M = 3.41$, $SD = 1.25$) or just gives objective information ($M = 3.29$, $SD = .76$; $t(71) = .45$, $p = .65$). If the organization uses an ex-post crisis timing strategy however, its credibility decreases if it only gives information about the crisis ($M = 2.58$, $SD = 1.10$) compared to when it adds a crisis response strategy ($M = 3.41$, $SD = 1.20$); $t(62) = 2.85$, $p = .006$). These results support H1a and H1b.

The second hypothesis is tested using a mediation analyses based on the Baron and Kenny (1986) procedure (cf. Table 1). In the first step, the effects of the independent variables, crisis response strategy and timing strategy on organizational reputation, are estimated. The results of the ANOVA show two significant main effects (crisis response strategy ($F(1, 133) = 4.52$, $p = .035$), crisis timing strategy ($F(1, 133) = 4.18$, $p = .043$)). The interaction effect of crisis response strategy and timing strategy on reputation is significant on the point one level ($F(1, 133) = 3.01$, $p = .085$).

In the second step of the procedure, the effect of the independent variables on the mediating variable, organizational credibility, is investigated. The ANOVA shows a significant main effect of crisis response strategy ($F(1, 133) = 6.44$, $p = .012$)

Table 1
Mediating effect of credibility on the impact of crisis timing strategy and crisis response strategy on organizational reputation.

Baron and Kenny steps	Relation	$F(1, 133)$	Partial Eta^2	P
Step 1	Crisis response strategy	4.52	.033	.035
	Crisis timing strategy	4.18	.031	.043
	Crisis response strategy × crisis timing strategy → reputation	3.009	.022	.085
Step 2	Crisis response strategy	6.44	.046	.012
	Crisis timing strategy	3.61	.026	.060
	Crisis response strategy × crisis timing strategy → credibility	3.70	.027	.056
Step 3	Crisis response strategy	.22	.002	.64
	Crisis timing strategy	.96	.007	.33
	Crisis response strategy × crisis timing strategy	.28	.002	.60
	Credibility (covariate) → reputation	129.20	.49	<.001

and a significant main effect of crisis timing strategy ($F(1, 133) = 3.61$, $p = .06$) on credibility. As mentioned in the previous analysis (see H1a and H1b), the interaction effect on credibility is significant ($F(1, 133) = 3.70$, $p = .056$).

In the third step of the procedure, the effects of the mediating and the independent variables on organizational reputation are estimated simultaneously. Hence, credibility was added as a covariate in the ANOVA analysis (cf. first step). Credibility has a strong positive effect on organizational reputation ($F(1, 132) = 129.20$, $p < 001$). The main effects of both crisis response strategy $F(1, 132) = .22$, $p = 64$) and timing are no longer significant ($F(1, 132) = .96$, $p = 33$). The interaction effect is also no longer significant ($F(1, 132) = .28$, $p = .60$). Hence, organizational credibility fully mediates the effects of crisis response strategy, crisis timing strategy and their interaction on organizational post-crisis reputation. These results support hypothesis 2.

6. Conclusions and suggestions for further research

The SCCT suggests that in case of a crisis that poses a severe reputational threat, it is necessary to use reputation restoring crisis response strategies in addition to offering stakeholders objective information about the crisis (Coombs, 2004). Preventable crises induce a high reputational threat, and often lead to a difficult choice among the different crisis response strategies. The use of denial strategies would be a mismatch according to SCCT guidelines (Coombs, 2007), as the organization is highly responsible. Accepting responsibility, however, might lead to lawsuits to demand compensation (Coombs & Holladay, 2002). A proper use of crisis timing strategies might make it suitable to give solely objective information in case of preventable crises.

This study confirms earlier findings on the use of crisis response strategies in ex-post crisis timing strategy situations (Coombs, 2004; Coombs & Holladay, 2008). If an organization reacts to thunder in a preventable crisis, it will be more credible if it uses a rebuild crisis response strategy in addition to offering objective information. Organizations in crisis can, however, communicate proactively by using an ex-ante crisis timing strategy. This should have an equally positive effect as compared to the use of crisis response strategies (Arpan & Roskos-Ewoldsen, 2005). The results confirm that in the ex-ante crisis timing strategy condition offering objective information about the crisis has the same impact on organizational credibility as the use of a crisis response strategy.

Former findings of the positive effects of an ex-ante crisis timing strategy were mainly found for organizational credibility, but not yet for organizational reputation. The positive effects of stealing thunder on perceptions of crisis severity and guilt were mediated by credibility (Arpan & Roskos-Ewoldsen, 2005; Williams et al., 1993). The results of this study equally show that the interaction between crisis timing and crisis response strategies on post-crisis reputation is mediated by organizational credibility.

The limitations of the current study provide some possibilities for further research. A first limitation is that reputation was measured after only one exposure to only one fictitious company. Further research is needed with real organizations from different industrial sectors. Secondly, we based the selection of respondents on a convenience sample. Further research should use a more systematic procedure to select the respondents and measure educational level in addition to gender and age to guarantee the representativeness of the sample. In addition, it has been suggested that ex-ante crisis timing strategies work best if they are followed by an attack from a third party (Easley, Bearden, & Teel, 1995). This study did not offer respondents that subsequent attack.

The current findings stress the importance of timing in addition to the content of crisis communication. The difficult choice among several crisis response strategies (apology, denial, etc.) can be avoided by simply selecting the right crisis timing strategy. The managerial implications of these results are that public relations practitioners have several options when confronted with a preventable crisis. They can avoid the difficulty of convincing the management or the legal department to take explicit responsibility for a crisis. If the organization's management or its legal department fear that an apology leads to financial losses, the organization can simply steal thunder and be the first to give stakeholders the factual information about a crisis, hereby minimizing reputational damage.

Acknowledgement

The authors would like to thank Ninia Baert for her help in collecting the data.

References

Archer, R. L. & Burleson, J. A. (1980). The effects of timing of self-disclosure on attraction and reciprocity. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, *38*(1), 120–130.

Arpan, L. M. & Pompper, D. (2003). Stormy weather: Testing "stealing thunder" as a crisis communication strategy to improve communication flow between organizations and journalists. *Public Relations Review*, *29*(3), 291–308.

Arpan, L. M. & Roskos-Ewoldsen, D. R. (2005). Stealing thunder: Analysis of the effects of proactive disclosure of crisis information. *Public Relations Review*, *31*(3), 425–433.

Baron, R. M. & Kenny, D. A. (1986). The moderator–mediator variable distinction in social psychological research: Conceptual, strategic, and statistical considerations. *Journal of Personality and Social Psychology*, *51*(6), 1173–1182.

Beltramini, R. (1982). Advertising perceived believability scale. In D. R. Corrigan, F. B. Kraft, & R. H. Ross (Eds.), *Proceedings of the Southwestern Marketing Association* (pp. 1–3). Wichita, KS: Southwestern Marketing Association, Wichita State University.

Coombs, W. T. (2004). West Pharmaceutical's explosion: Structuring crisis discourse knowledge. *Public Relations Review*, *30*(4), 467–473.

Coombs, W. T. (2007). Protecting organization reputations during a crisis: The development and application of situational crisis communication theory. *Corporate Reputation Review*, *10*(3), 163–176.
Coombs, W. T. & Holladay, S. J. (1996). Communication and attributions in a crisis: An experimental study in crisis communication. *Journal of Public Relations Research*, *8*(4), 279–295.
Coombs, W. T. & Holladay, S. J. (2002). Helping crisis managers protect reputational assets: Initial tests of the situational crisis communication theory. *Management Communication Quarterly*, *16*(2), 165–186.
Coombs, W. T. & Holladay, S. J. (2008). Comparing apology to equivalent crisis response strategies: Clarifying apology's role and value in crisis communication. *Public Relations Review*, *34*(3), 252–257.
Dolnik, L., Case, T. I. & Williams, K. D. (2003). Stealing thunder as a courtroom tactic revisited: Processes and boundaries. *Law and Human Behavior*, *27*(3), 267–287.
Easley, R. W., Bearden, W. O. & Teel, J. E. (1995). Testing predictions derived from inoculation theory and the effectiveness of self-disclosure communication strategies. *Journal of Business Research*, *34*(2), 93–105.
Fombrun, C. J., Gardberg, N. A. & Sever, J. M. (2000). The reputation quotient sm: A multi-stakeholder measure of corporate reputation. *The Journal of Brand Management*, *7*(4), 241–255.
Griffin, M., Babin, B. J. & Darden, W. R. (1992). Consumer assessments of responsibility for product-related injuries: The impact of regulations, warnings, and promotional policies. *Advances in Consumer Research*, *19*(1), 870–878.
Huang, Y. (2006). Crisis situations, communication strategies, and media coverage: A multicase study revisiting the communicative response model. *Communication Research*, *33*(3), 180–205.
Mauet, T. A. (2007). *Trial techniques* (7th ed.). New York: Aspen Publishers.
Williams, K. D., Bourgeois, M. J. & Croyle, R. T. (1993). The effects of stealing thunder in criminal and civil trials. *Law and Human Behavior*, *17*(6), 597–609.